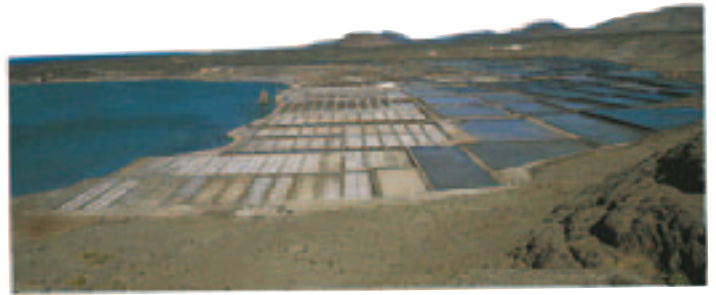


SHINY PEARLS

Pearls are produced by mussels and oysters in response to irritation. Natural pearls form around a piece of grit that gets between the oyster's shell and its skin (mantle). Tissues from the mantle surround the grit to produce mother-of-pearl layers. Pearls are cultivated by inserting particles into a clam, along with some skin from another clam. Many kinds of clams produce pearls, but only those with shiny, inner layers to the shell make shiny pearls.

Shell can close to protect itself from predators

Double strand of blue pearls



SALT PANS

When seawater evaporates, a salt-crystal crust is left behind. Large quantities of sea salt are produced by flooding shallow ponds (pans) with seawater and letting the water evaporate in the hot sun. Sea salt is produced in places with warm weather and little rain. The salt in seawater is mostly sodium chloride, but there is also sulphate, magnesium, calcium, and potassium.

Noble pen shell grows to 2 ft (60 cm) in length



Gloves can be made from byssus threads of noble pen shell

Tapered shell is brittle



Silver cross inlaid with abalone shell

Hole to expel water and waste

Byssus threads made by shell to anchor it to the seabed



GOLDEN THREADS

The pen shell produces a thick mat of byssus threads to anchor it in the soft seabed of the Mediterranean. These threads were once collected, spun into fine, golden thread, and then woven into cloth. Some say the cloth may have started the legend of the golden fleece of Ancient Greek mythology, where the fleece was that of a winged ram.

RAINBOW HUES

Inside an abalone shell are all the colors of the rainbow. The heavy shell's mother-of-pearl is used to make jewellery and buttons. These shells are popular with New Zealand's Maoris. Abalones are also eaten. With a muscular foot that clings to the seabed, the shells have to be prised off the bottom.

